WATER AND ALCOHOL

Keeping water fresh at sea was beyond the technological capacity of the age of sail. It corrupted in the barrels, a problem only solved by the use of iron storage tanks in the 19th century. Instead, sailors mostly drank beer or wine. A sailor in Nelson's Royal Navy was allowed a gallon (4.5 liters) of beer a day. There was also a daily rum ration of half a pint (280 ml) per man, drunk mixed with water as "grog." However, punishments for men drunk on duty were severe. Concern about alcohol led to the reduction of the Royal Navy rum ration to an eighth of a pint (70 ml) by the 1850s. The US Navy stopped alcohol rations in 1862 and banned all alcohol on board warships in 1914.



ISSUING THE GROG Men gather aboard the *Royal Sovereign* in 1895. Teetotallers could claim the money value of the rum, or its equivalent in cocoa and sugar.



RUM BARRELS The red line on the top of the barrel indicated its contents of rum. Rum gradually replaced brandy as the Royal Navy's official daily ration after the British capture of Jamaica in 1655.

> *The stench of 51 sweating seamen, diesel oil, rotting food, and moldy bread mingled with the noisome odors that emanated from the galley and the two tiny washrooms.*
>
> **HERBERT A. WERNER** *Iron Coffins*, describing the unappetizing conditions in a U-Boat in World War II



COMPACT KITCHEN With room for only two to three people, this is one of several cooking areas on board the Greek armored cruiser *Georgios Averof*, active from 1910 to 1952.

CRAMPED CONFINES The unchanging problem of limited space calls for multi-purpose areas. Here 1950s sailors bunk and mess in the same room.



MASS PRODUCTION The bakery on board the US aircraft carrier *George Washington* provides bread for 6,000 crew members. A far remove from early days of unvarying fare, there are specially catered meals and even an ice-cream stand available on board.

MODERN INNOVATIONS

The introduction of canned foods, followed later by refrigeration, improved nutrition on board through the 19th century. Also the increase in the speed of steamships shortened times at sea, making use of fresh ingredients more feasible. In Britain's Royal Navy in 1914, potatoes, powdered soup, smoked salmon, and milky tea were on the menu, although men still ate in messes eight to a bench with a table that probably doubled as a bed. During World War II self-service cafeterias became common on larger ships, though this brought no end to seamen's grumbling about food.